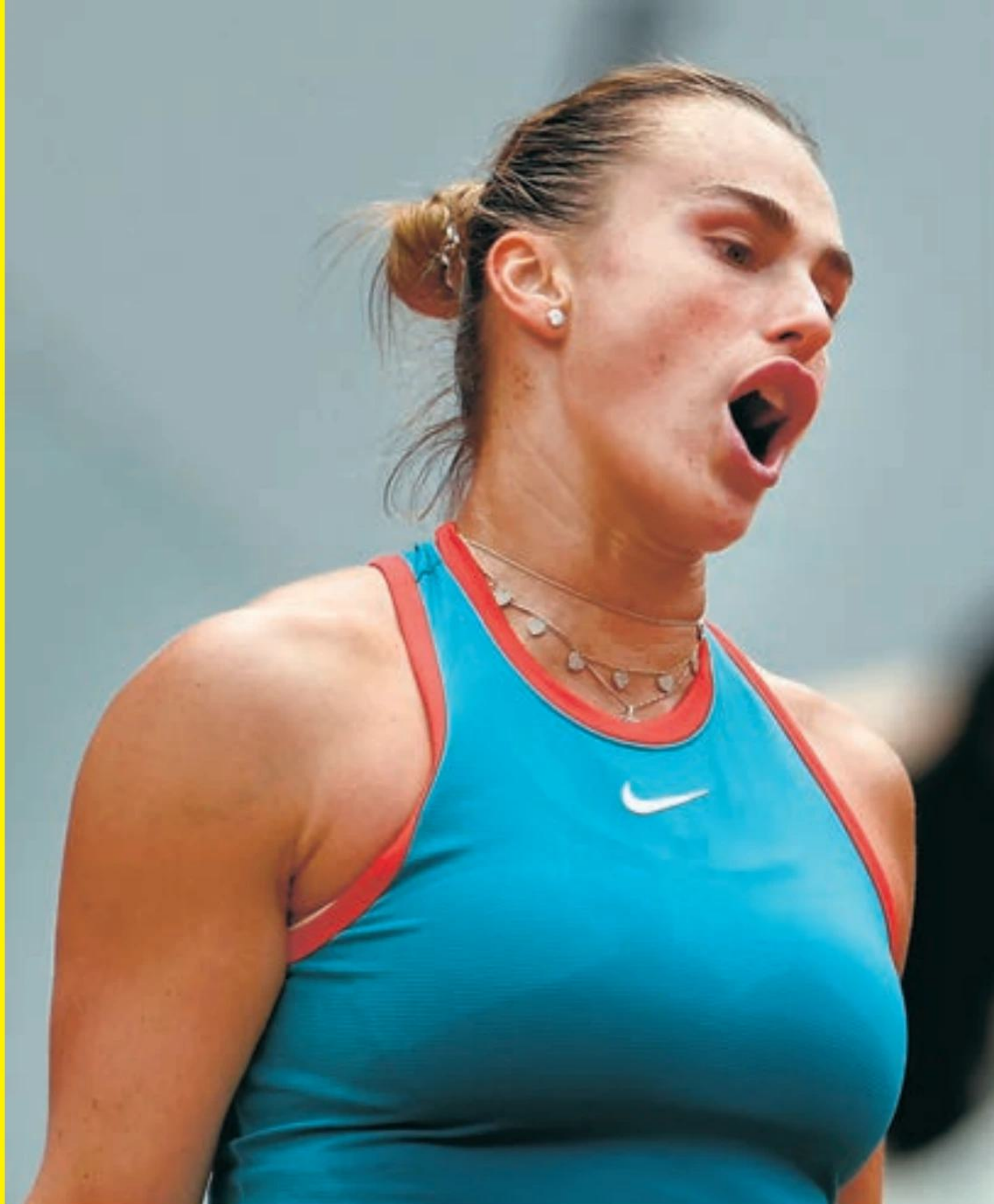




Big setback: Sabalenka, who had beaten defending champion Iga Swiatek, was the favourite to win the final. AFP

and the Australian Open final in January to Madison Keys — haunting her now? Gauff's shot variety and foot speed were breaking down Sabalenka's power-ball game and poise. Sabalenka managed a service break but still trailed 4-2 in the second set. Then Gauff poured it on, taking eight straight points, the last on a put-away overhead, to wrap up the 6-2 set.

"Sabalenka has been all over the place," said Davenport. "Let's see if she can dominate play and look like the No. 1."

If history were any guide, Sabalenka had reason to worry. Before the final, she was a mediocre 17-17 in three-set matches at Majors compared to Gauff's splendid 17-6. In

fact, Gauff was 10-2 since the start of 2023. Benefitting from in-match coaching, Gauff moved forward from four feet behind the baseline in the first set to two feet inside it thereafter to win eight of the next 11 games. The positional pressure worked. The Belarusian blinked

first in the deciding set, double faulting to lose her serve and fall behind 2-1. Yelling in Russian at her camp seemed to help as she broke back for 3-all. But a boomerang break — at love! — put Gauff ahead for good at 4-3.

Minutes later, the discombobulated Sabalenka made three unforced errors to wind up Gauff's 6-7 (5), 6-2, 6-4 triumph. Gauff fell onto her back, hopped up to shake hands with Sabalenka, and shed tears of joy, relief and satisfaction on her chair. During the trophy presentation, Sabalenka, with tears flowing, tried to compose herself as she praised Gauff, thanked her team, and apologised, "I'm sorry for this terrible final."

"Coco stayed so calm and positive through so many twists and turns," summed up Davenport. In sharp contrast, noted Stephens, "Aryna did not control any emotions, and that lost her the match. It wasn't about tennis. She battled herself and Coco."

Despite the disappointing final, Sabalenka had much to be proud of during her best Roland-Garros performance. The Belarusian Basher powered through a draw much tougher than Gauff's with convincing wins over resurgent No. 16 Amanda Anisimova 7-5, 6-3, who had beaten Sabalenka in five of their previous seven matches, No. 8 and Olympic gold medallist Zheng Qinwen 7-6(3), 6-3, and the Queen of Clay, Swiatek (left).

No stone unturned

Swiatek led Sabalenka in their rivalry, 8-4 and 5-1 on clay. But those stats were misleading because the 23-year-old Pole hadn't won a tournament since taking her fourth Roland-Garros title a year ago, and her ranking dropped to No. 5.

Swiatek changed coaches, hiring highly regarded Wim Fissette, but still played a predictable one-dimensional baseline game built around her superb forehand and foot speed. Conversely, Sabalenka left no stone unturned to add to



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